CORE MECHANICS & RESOLUTION

In Corsair, the story unfolds through a conversation between the players and the Game Master (GM). The players narrate the actions of their characters, describing what they want to do, where they want to go, and what they say. The GM, in turn, narrates the world around the characters. The GM describes the environment, controls the non-player characters, and explains how the world reacts to the players' actions.

Most of the time, this back-and-forth is all that's needed. If a player says, *"I walk across the room and open the door,"* and there's no reason they couldn't, the GM simply says, *"Okay, you open the door and see..."*

However, sometimes a character attempts an action where the outcome is uncertain. Can the character leap across a chasm? Can they persuade a fugitive with a gun to stand down? Can they land a hit with their sidearm if they don't? In these moments, when the drama and tension of the story hang in the balance, we turn to the dice to see what happens. This is the heart of the game's mechanics, and it's where the rules of Corsair come into play.

ATTRIBUTES

In Corsair, any significant feature of a person, creature, or object can be represented by an **Attribute**. Attributes are a way to assign a numerical value to a characteristic, making it a concrete element of the game world. Anything and everything can have Attributes.

While characters have core Attributes representing their physical and mental capabilities—**Strength**, **Agility**, **Finesse**, **Instinct**, **Knowledge**, and **Presence**—the concept extends to all corners of the game:

- **Strength:** Raw physical power, muscular force, and bodily mass. Used for lifting heavy cargo, forcing jammed airlocks, overpowering opponents in hand-to-hand combat, and carrying heavy equipment.
- **Agility:** Whole-body speed, balance, and athletic coordination. Used for sprinting between cover, dodging incoming hazards, vaulting obstacles, and maneuvering in zero-gravity.
- **Finesse:** Manual dexterity, surgical precision, and fine motor control. Used for aiming firearms, picking mechanical locks, performing delicate surgery, and manipulating intricate instruments.
- **Knowledge:** Formal education, technical literacy, and deductive reasoning. Used for slicing computer security, analyzing sensor telemetry, operating starship consoles, and understanding alien relics.
- **Presence:** Force of personality, charisma, and commanding social authority. Used for negotiating deals, intimidating rivals, inspiring companions, and maintaining composure under intense pressure.
- **Instinct:** Intuition, acute situational alertness, and gut-level reflexes. Used for sensing impending ambushes, detecting hidden hazards, reading an adversary's unspoken intent, and reacting in the chaos of battle.

Beyond living characters, the concept of Attributes extends to all corners of the game. A weapon might have **Rate of Fire** and **Accuracy** as Attributes. A jetpack could have a **Thrust** Attribute, while a cybernetic arm might have a **Power** rating. A starship is defined by a whole range of Attributes, such as its **Thrusters**, **Hull**, and **Scanners**. These ratings are the primary factor in determining the outcome of an action. A higher Attribute value signifies greater capability, directly impacting the dice rolls you'll make during the game.

ATTRIBUTE PAIRS

When a situation calls for a die roll, the GM will determine the two most relevant Attributes to form an **Attribute Pair**. This pair becomes the foundation of the test. The choice of Attributes is always dependent on the context of the action being performed.

It's important to note that the same Attribute can be selected twice if the action calls for a focused application of that single quality. For example, lifting a heavy crate might call for a **Strength + Strength** test, representing a pure application of raw power. Additionally, when a test specifies only a single Attribute, it should be understood as a test where both Attributes in the Attribute Pair are that specified Attribute.

Here are a few examples of how these might be combined into Attribute Pairs:

- **Accuracy (of the gun) + Finesse:** To fire a ranged weapon.
- **Manouverability (of the spaceship) + Instinct:** To carefully pilot a shuttle through a dense asteroid field.
- **Strength + Presence:** To intimidate a guard with a show of force.
- **Knowledge + Instinct:** To investigate a crime scene, look for clues and deduce what happened.

TESTS

When the outcome of an action is uncertain, the GM will call for a test. There are three types of tests in Corsair: **Simple**, **Success**, and **Complex**.

SIMPLE TESTS

A Simple Test is used when the outcome of an action is binary: you either succeed or you fail. There is no middle ground. To make a Simple Test, you form a dice pool by taking a number of ten-sided dice (d10s) equal to the higher of the two Attributes in the pair. In order to succeed, you need at least one of the dice to roll an 8 or higher (also called a *Hit*). If it does, you succeed; if it doesn't, you fail.

Examples of Simple Tests include:

- Leaping across a chasm.
- Sneaking through a patrolled corridor.
- Disarming a trap.

SUCCESS TESTS

A Success Test is used for actions that are certain to succeed, but the degree of success is variable. The question isn't *if* you can do it, but *how well* you do it in the time available. For a Success Test, you form a dice pool using a number of d10s equal to the *higher* of the two Attributes in the pair. The highest single die roll from the pool becomes your **success points**, which measures how effectively you performed the action.

Examples of Success Tests include:

- Applying first aid to a wounded crewmate to see how many wounds you can patch up.
- Spending a day in the workshop repairing your ship to see how much progress you make.
- Moving around the battlefield and seeing how much distance you cover.

COMPLEX TESTS

Complex Tests are for situations where you need to know both *if* an action is successful and *how* successful it is. This is most common in combat, where you need to know if an attack hits and, if it does, how much damage it deals. A Complex Test is a two-step process:

1. **The Action Roll:** First, you make a roll to see if you succeed at all. This is identical to a Simple Test: you roll a number of d10s equal to the **higher** of the two Attributes in the pair. If your highest die is a 7 or lower, your action fails.
2. **The Success Roll:** If your Action Roll is a success (at least one die shows 8 or higher), you then determine the *quality* of your success. You take a number of dice from the successful roll equal to the **lower** of the two Attributes. The highest value on these dice becomes your "success points."

Essentially, a Complex Test combines a Simple Test to see if you hit, and a Success Test to see how well you hit.

THE IMPORTANCE OF NARRATION

It is crucial to understand that the GM determines the type of test and the Attribute Pair based on *how you describe your character's actions*. Your narration matters. The choices you make in describing an action can change the Attributes used, and therefore the dice you roll.

For example, let's say your character is trying to persuade an NPC:

- If you say, *"I try to reason with him, surely he will see my point in all this,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Knowledge** test, splashing in Knowledge for the reasoning part.
- If you instead say, *"I put on all the charm my character has and try to appeal to him that way,"* the GM will call for a **Presence + Presence** test.
- If you narrate, *"I get all up in his face and make it very clear to him in no uncertain terms that he will do as I say,"* the GM will call for a **Strength + Presence** test.
- And if you instead say, *"I hold my gun to his head and start counting,"* the GM could still ask for the **Damage** or the **Load** (size) of the gun and say roll that plus your **Presence**.

UPGRADES AND DOWNGRADES

Situational factors can influence the outcome of a test. A character might have a significant advantage, like using a high-quality tool, or a disadvantage, like working in a hazardous environment. These are represented by **Upgrades** and **Downgrades**:

- **Upgrade:** For each net **Upgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to a twelve-sided die (d12). If all the dice in your pool are already d12s, each further **Upgrade** adds a new d10 to the pool.
- **Downgrade:** For each net **Downgrade**, you change one of the d10s in your dice pool to an eight-sided die (d8). If all the dice in your pool are already d8s, each further **Downgrade** forces you to remove a d8 from the pool.

Before any roll, the GM assesses the situation and assigns Upgrades for advantages and Downgrades for disadvantages. These cancel each other out on a 1-to-1 basis (e.g., 3 Upgrades and 2 Downgrades yields a net of 1 Upgrade).

The net number of Upgrades or Downgrades has a **maximum limit of 6**. If you have 8 Upgrades and 1 Downgrade, you have a net of 7 Upgrades, but you apply only 6 to the roll. In the rare case that you run out of all dice to downgrade, the test is extremely difficult: you roll two d8s and must take the lower result.

THE GAMBIT SYSTEM

Gambit is a special resource that allows players to snatch victory from the jaws of defeat. It's a pool of dice that you can use to turn a failed roll into a success.

EARNING GAMBIT

You earn **Gambit** by taking risks. After you roll your dice pool for a test, if any die shows its maximum possible value (e.g., a 10 on a d10, or a 12 on a d12), you have a choice. You can either use that die as part of your test as normal, or you can "bank" it for later. If you choose to bank it, you remove the die from your current roll and add it to your personal **Gambit** pool. This die can then be spent on a future roll.

SPENDING GAMBIT

You can spend a **Gambit** die from your pool on any test your character makes. You can declare you are spending **Gambit** at any point during the test—before you roll, after you see the results, anytime. When you spend a **Gambit** die, you simply add it to your current dice pool and roll it. Its result is added to the other dice, potentially changing the outcome of the test.

When a player spends a **Gambit** die, and the dice pool has already been modified by **Upgrades** or **Downgrades**, the newly added **Gambit** die retains its original die type.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF GAMBIT

There is one crucial restriction on using **Gambit**: **a player can either spend or gain Gambit during a test, but not both.** This means that if you spend any **Gambit** from your pool on a test, you cannot choose to bank any dice from that test to earn new **Gambit**. Conversely, if you bank a die from a roll to earn a **Gambit**, you cannot spend any **Gambit** on that same test.

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER: AN EXAMPLE TEST

Let's see how all these elements come together in play:

- **The Scenario:** Serving an apprehension warrant against an armed syndicate cell in an unpoliced orbital warehouse, Jax, a nimble gunslinger, is pinned down behind a cargo container. An outlaw skirmisher is advancing on his position, laying down suppressing fire. Jax decides to pop up and take a quick shot at the suspect with his sidearm. The GM decides this is a **Complex Test**, as they need to know if the shot hits and how much damage it deals. Jax's player describes the action as a quick, precise shot, so the GM chooses the Attribute Pair: **Finesse + Accuracy**. Jax has **Finesse 4**, his sidearm has **Accuracy 3**, and he holds two d10s in his Gambit pool.
- **1. The Action Roll (Did the shot hit?):** For the first part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the higher of the two Attributes (**Finesse 4**), assembling a dice pool of **4d10**. He rolls `[2, 4, 5, 7]`. The highest result is 7 (a miss). Jax spends a Gambit die: *"I'm spending a Gambit."* He rolls the banked d10 and gets an `[8]`. His pool is now `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. With an 8, the shot hits!
- **2. The Success Roll (How much damage was dealt?):** For the second part of a Complex Test, Jax uses the lower Attribute (**Accuracy 3**), taking the 3 highest dice from his pool: `[5, 7, 8]`. The highest die is an 8 (8 points of damage). Jax decides to maximize the damage: *"I'm spending my second Gambit die."* He rolls his second banked d10 and rolls a `[9]`. His Success pool is now `[5, 7, 8, 9]`. The highest result is a 9.
- **Resolution:** Jax deals 9 points of damage to the outlaw, taking them down before they can breach his cover. Spending his banked Gambit turned a clean miss into a devastating shot.

CONTESTING A TEST

Often, a test isn't just against a static obstacle; it's against an active opponent who is trying to interfere. When a character is the target of another character's test (like being shot at, deceived, or tackled), they have the opportunity to contest.

In order to contest an action taken by another creature, you must be in close physical proximity to its target—typically sharing the immediate space with them. For example, you can contest an attack coming at you or an ally right beside you, and you can contest an enemy's movement crossing your space. On the other hand, you cannot contest a hostile creature reviving an ally 40 meters away by shooting at them.

To perform a **Contest**, the defending creature rolls a **Simple Test** determined by the GM (called a **Contest Roll**). Each die landing **8 or higher (a Hit)** eliminates the highest die from the roll you contested.

You **resist** a test if your Contest Roll eliminates every 8+ die from the contested roll.

You can contest **Success Tests** as well. If, after contesting, no 8+ dice remain in the contested character's pool, the Success Test generates **0 Success Points**, even if there are dice that are yet to be eliminated.

You can also contest actions that would normally not require a test (such as shushing someone before they can speak, or preventing an enemy you knocked prone from standing up). When this happens, you declare your intent to contest, and the contested creature must decide if they are willing to perform a **Simple Test** to complete their action—which you can then contest—or forego it altogether.

CONTEST EXAMPLE

Returning to our gunslinger Jax: suppose Jax fires at a fleeing syndicate smuggler trying to reach an airlock, rolling `[2, 4, 5, 7, 8]`. The suspect has an **Evasion** of 3 and dives behind reinforced deck piping. The GM calls for an Evasion Contest Roll (**3d10**). The smuggler rolls `[3, 8, 9]`—scoring two Hits (8 and 9). These two Hits eliminate Jax's two highest dice (the 8 and the 7). Jax's remaining pool is `[2, 4, 5]`. With no die of 8 or higher remaining, the attack becomes a **Failure**; the round ricochets harmlessly off the reinforced piping as the suspect scrambles out of the line of fire.

TEAMWORK

Sometimes, a single character isn't enough for the job. When multiple characters cooperate on the same task at the same time—forcing open a hydraulic blast door, infiltrating past a vigilant patrol, or executing a coordinated breach—they can use **Teamwork**.

JOINING A TEAMWORK ACTION

Any character's action can be turned into a **Teamwork Test** by additional eligible characters declaring their intent to join. A character can join a Teamwork action if:

- **Proximity:** The participants are in close physical proximity to each other and their shared objective.
- **Appropriate Contribution:** Each participant rolls the Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon, gear, or method of action. Participants do not need to roll the same Attribute Pair! For example, two characters forcing a heavy blast door might both roll **Strength + Strength**, but in a coordinated combat assault, one character might swing a warhammer (**Strength + Finesse**, Striking) while an ally thrusts with a combat knife (**Agility + Finesse**, Piercing). Because all tests evaluate Hits on an 8 or higher, dice can be swapped freely between pools regardless of which attributes generated them.
- **Shared Target or Objective:** If the action has a target or destination, it must be identical for all participants (firing on the same enemy, treating the same wounded ally, forcing the same bulkhead).
- **Logical Feasibility:** The task must be something that multiple people can realistically cooperate on simultaneously.

THE DICE SWAP

After all participants declare their intent to cooperate, everyone rolls their respective test pools simultaneously. Once the dice hit the table, **any two participants can swap any amount of dice between their pools**. The strategic purpose of this exchange is mutual support: characters with surplus high-value dice (8+) pass extra results to allies who rolled low, ensuring the entire team achieves its goal or shaves away vulnerabilities.

CONTESTING TEAMWORK: DEFENDER'S ADVANTAGE

When an adversary is targeted by a Teamwork action, the defender gains the **Defender's Advantage**:

1. **Team Rolls:** All attacking participants roll their dice pools simultaneously.
2. **Team Swaps:** Attackers coordinate and commit their dice distribution.
3. **Defender Rolls:** The defender rolls their Contest pool *after* the attackers commit their dice swap.
4. **Targeted Elimination:** Each Hit (8+) on the Contest Roll allows the defender to eliminate the highest die from **whichever participating attacker's pool the defender chooses**. The defender can focus all Hits onto a single attacker to knock them out of the test, or split Hits across multiple foes.
5. **Knocking Attackers Out:** In a Complex Test, if the defender eliminates all 8+ dice from an attacker's pool, that attacker fails their Action Roll completely and **cannot advance to the Success Roll**. Only attackers who retain an 8+ move forward to roll damage!

COMPLEX TESTS & CONTESTS IN TEAMWORK

Teamwork can be employed across both stages of a Complex Test. Surviving attackers roll their Success pools and may **swap dice between their Success pools as well**, funneling high dice onto an operative with high-damage weapons or critical effects.

Defenders can also use Teamwork to resist incoming actions: when multiple defenders coordinate to resist an action, they roll their contest pools simultaneously, swap dice to maximize total

SCENES, PACING, AND ACTION

Corsair's gameplay is structured to keep the action moving and give every character a chance to shine. The story unfolds in Scenes, which are the fundamental building blocks of your adventure. However, not all scenes are paced the same. The GM can control the narrative flow by "zooming in" or "zooming out" on the action, changing the scope of a scene from a single, heart-pounding moment to the events of an entire day.

The game distinguishes between three types of scenes based on their scope: **Moment to Moment**, **Place to Place**, and **Day to Day**.

SCENE TYPES AND PACING

Think of the scene type as a camera lens. The GM can zoom in for a close-up on a dramatic confrontation or zoom out to quickly cover a long journey:

- **Day to Day:** This is the most "zoomed-out" level of play. It's used to cover long periods of time in which the characters are engaged in ongoing activities, but nothing requires immediate, second-by-second attention. This could be a day spent repairing the ship, a week of interstellar travel, or a month of downtime in a bustling city.
- **Place to Place:** This is the mid-level scope, focusing on a specific location and the events that unfold there. It's used for exploring a space station, navigating a dangerous asteroid field, or investigating a crime scene. Time is more fluid here than in Moment to Moment play, but the focus is on a single, contiguous area.
- **Moment to Moment:** This is the most "zoomed-in" level of play, where every second counts. This is for high-stakes situations like combat, a frantic chase, or a tense negotiation.

ACTION POINTS

Action Points are the currency you spend to perform significant actions, especially those requiring a Test. Every player has a maximum of **3 Action Points**.

Every test you take, whether it be Simple, Success, or Complex, requires **1 Action Point**. In some cases the GM might also call on you to spend an Action Point without taking a test, for example, to transit from one major location to the next.

ROUNDS

Within any scene, the action is broken down into **Rounds**. A round is a period of in-game time appropriate to the scene's pacing, where every character present has an opportunity to act. This ensures that the chaos of a situation is manageable and that the spotlight is shared.

A round in moment-to-moment pacing is only a dozen or so seconds long. In place-to-place pacing, a round might last from minutes to a few hours, while in day-to-day pacing, it's a full day.

At the start of every Round, every creature refills their Action Points to the maximum.

When the round ends, the GM gets an opportunity to introduce new characters into the scene, based on the broader scope of the scene that's playing out and the amount of time that passed during the round. This can be new reinforcements arriving in a moment-to-moment gunfight, or an inspection from the local authorities while you are going place-to-place. This also lets the GM advance the plot via NPCs that are acting outside the ongoing scene.

TURNS

Each round is divided into multiple turns of two different types: The **Player Turn** and the **GM Turn**.

- **Player Turn:** During the Player Turn, the players decide and declare what their characters are doing. A crucial aspect of the Player Turn is its free-form nature. **Players can act in any order they wish.** You can coordinate your actions, set up combos, and react to each other's decisions dynamically. One player might act, then another, then the first player might act again.
- **GM Turn:** During the GM Turn, the Game Master narrates the actions of the non-player characters (NPCs) in the scene. This is when every NPC makes their moves. If there are no NPCs in the scene other than the players, the GM turn is skipped, and it's the Player's Turn again.

The turn swaps from the players to the GM (or vice versa) after the active side has spent a total of **2 or more Action Points** and resolved their last action. The round concludes when both sides choose to "pass," meaning they have no further actions to take. Every round starts with the Player Turn first.

Most rounds will fly by due to the players being grounded with no NPCs, or NPCs that generally don't wish to affect the player characters. Therefore, most rounds will be rather one-sided, but that is a good thing as the GM already has a lot of work just arbitrating the player characters' narrations.

When a player action causes an NPC to go from a passive to an active participant in the scene, they become active and receive their Action Points next round, meaning each player character has a chance to act before the GM gets to react with NPCs.

GOING FIRST

Every round begins with the Player Turn. The players always act first, coordinating their moves and executing their strategies before the GM responds with the actions of non-player characters.

TEAMWORK ACTIONS

Teamwork allows multiple characters to contribute to a single goal. When characters use Teamwork, they can spend their Action Points to contribute to the collective effort. While players spending Action Points to participate in a Teamwork Test counts towards the 2AP per Turn limit, reaching the limit doesn't stop additional characters from participating. The turn will only end once the Teamwork Test has resolved.

TEAMWORK EXAMPLE: CHECKPOINT INFILTRATION

The crew is working an undercover assignment tracking a fugitive into an outlaw-run freeport. To reach the lower docks without tipping off the local syndicate, they must pass through an enforcer-controlled checkpoint. The GM rules this will be a Teamwork action, requiring each character to make a Success Test to see how well they blend into the underworld foot traffic:

- Silas, a master of disguise, creates a subtle diversion at a cargo terminal and scores 2 hits.
- Griz, a large and imposing figure, tries to look inconspicuous by pretending to be an off-shift maintenance hauler, but fails miserably, scoring no hits.
- Jax, ever the opportunist, strikes up a casual conversation with one of the gang lookouts to draw their attention, scoring just one hit.

The players have now collectively spent 3 Action Points. Silas swaps one of his hits for one of Griz's dice, representing the operatives covering for each other's slip-ups and successfully slipping past the checkpoint as a cohesive unit.

The flexibility of the turn structure and Action Point system is designed to encourage creative problem-solving and dynamic, cinematic action. Don't be afraid to combine actions, work together, and push your characters to their limits.

DELAYED ACTIONS

During high-stakes encounters, characters do not always act immediately; often, a disciplined Corsair holds their fire until an enemy leaves cover, waits for an incoming threat to breach a threshold, or readies a shot to interrupt a hostile move. You can prepare for such moments by declaring a **Delayed Action**:

- **Setting Up (1 AP):** On your turn, you spend **1 Action Point** to prepare a delayed action. When declaring a delayed action, you must specify two things:
  1. **The Trigger:** The observable event or condition you are reacting to (e.g., *"when an enemy steps out of cover," "if Brant draws a sidearm,"* or *"when the blast door starts to open"*).
  2. **The Planned Action:** The specific action you intend to take when the trigger occurs. The planned action must be manageable within **1 AP** (such as taking a shot with a firearm, swinging a melee weapon, making a Simple Test, or moving up to your base movement distance).
- **Declaring Timing (Before vs. After):** You have tactical freedom over when your action resolves relative to the trigger, but you must declare your timing beforehand when setting it up:
  - **Reacting Before (Interrupt):** You act *before* the triggering event resolves. For instance, declaring that you will shoot at a target the moment they attempt to fire at you allows you to shoot first, potentially eliminating or disrupting them before their attack can land.
  - **Reacting After (Response):** You act *after* the triggering event has completed. For instance, waiting until an enemy has moved completely out from behind heavy cover into open ground before firing ensures they cannot claim cover bonuses against your attack.
- **Action Point & Turn Accounting:** The 1 AP cost is paid **on the turn you set up the delayed action**, counting against the 2 AP limit of that turn. When the trigger condition occurs and you take your action, it requires **0 additional AP** in that moment, and it does not count against the AP limit of the turn in which it triggers.
- **Resolution and Expiration:** When the trigger condition is met, you immediately execute the declared test or action. If the triggering condition does not occur before the end of the round, the prepared action expires without effect—the spent Action Point represents the time, readiness, and vigilance invested in holding your position.
- **Delayed Teamwork Actions:** Multiple characters can coordinate to set up a shared delayed action (such as establishing a crossfire overwatch or setting a synchronized ambush):
  - **Setup:** All participants must share the same space, spend **1 AP** each, and agree upon the exact same **Trigger**, **Target**, and **Timing** (Before or After). Each participant prepares the action and Attribute Pair appropriate to their weapon or tool. An ally can spend 1 AP on a subsequent turn to join an existing ally's delayed action if they enter their space.
  - **Triggering & Swapping:** When the trigger condition occurs, all linked participants roll simultaneously for **0 additional AP** and can swap dice between their pools under standard Teamwork rules. If the target contests, Defender's Advantage applies normally.
  - **Disruption:** If an individual participant is incapacitated, knocked out of the space, or forced to defend before the trigger occurs, their readied action is broken, but remaining allies can still execute their delayed action when the condition is met.

ZOOMING IN AND OUT

The GM can transition between scene types as the story demands:

- **Zooming In:** When a broader scene suddenly becomes more dangerous or dramatic, the GM can "zoom in." For example, while the crew is executing a recovery warrant aboard an abandoned freighter (Place to Place), they might be ambushed by barricaded pirate scavengers, instantly shifting the scene to Moment to Moment. When zooming in, all characters present in the scene synchronize their broader Action Points down to the lowest remaining AP among them (reflecting time elapsed together). They then refill their Action Points in the new, narrower pacing to their maximum (3 AP) and begin a fresh round. Any ongoing effects created in the broader pacing are retained.
- **Zooming Out:** When a high-stakes scene concludes, the GM "zooms out" back to the broader pacing. Players set aside their tactical Action Points and resume the broader pacing with their remaining broader Action Points. If characters still have Action Points remaining in that broader round, they continue their shift or day; if all broader AP have been spent, the broader round concludes at the End of the Round. Characters operating in parallel in other locations retain their unspent broader AP and can take actions during that same timeframe.

EFFECTS

While succeeding at a test achieves your immediate objective, game mechanics in Corsair invite you to shape the battleground, create tactical openings, and alter the narrative flow of a scene. This is accomplished through Effects. Rather than relying solely on standard outcomes, Effects allow you to convert exceptional rolls into dynamic opportunities—turning a single strike into a sweeping attack, driving an opponent backward, or setting up a defensive barrier for an ally.

ACTIVATING EFFECTS

To activate an Effect, you sacrifice **Hits**—dice displaying a result of 8 or higher—rolled during an Action Roll or a Success Roll, depending on the specific Effect's requirements.

Activating an Effect is an exercise in collaborative storytelling between you and the Game Master. The Effect you declare must align logically with your character's action, declared narration, and chosen Attribute Pair. For instance, you cannot use an attack roll with a rifle to push a heavy blast door shut across the room, but you could easily describe forcing an enemy backward into cover or shooting out a control panel. The GM retains final discretion on whether an Effect fits naturally into the unfolding fiction.

ACTION EFFECTS

Action Effects are activated during your **Action Roll**. By setting aside Hits before moving on to resolve your Success Roll, you can manipulate the immediate environment or extend the reach of your action:

- **Chain Effect:** When performing an action directed at a single target out of several eligible choices—most commonly during combat—you may spend Hits on a **Chain Effect**. For each Hit you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you select one additional eligible target to include in the action. When chaining a Complex Test, perform a single Success Roll using the lower Attribute; the highest die applies individually to every target caught in the chain. You cannot chain actions that naturally affect multiple targets by default. Furthermore, if the base action requires expending a specific resource (such as ammunition, power cells, or consumable gear), you must pay that resource cost separately for each chained target. When making a ranged attack, you can only chain targets in the same range band, and the combined use of Chain and Crit effects cannot exceed your weapon's Rate of Fire (RoF).
- **Upgrade and Downgrade Effect:** When your action creates a clear situational advantage for yourself or an impending disadvantage for an enemy, you can activate an **Upgrade or Downgrade Effect**. Each Hit spent from your Action Roll allows you to step up or step down a die on subsequent tests related to that altered circumstance. Crucially, if you are resolving a Complex Test, you may apply this effect immediately to step up dice on your own upcoming Success Roll without needing to specify the situational advantage.
- **Blocker Effect:** If your narration aims to hinder, interrupt, or prevent an enemy from carrying out a specific future action, you can establish a **Blocker Effect**. For every **2 Hits** you sacrifice from your Action Roll, you set aside 1 Hit to create a pool of defensive dice. When an opponent attempts the blocked action, each set-aside Hit negates the single highest die from their test pool before resolving. Once a set-aside Hit negates an opponent's die, that set-aside Hit is expended. The Blocker Effect persists until all set-aside Hits are exhausted. If an opponent attempts to perform an action that normally does not require a test (such as opening a latch or standing up), the Blocker forces them to execute a **Simple Test** first; failing to eliminate all set-aside Hits prevents them from completing the action.

SUSTAINED EFFECTS

Certain Effects can be sustained over time rather than depleting after a single use. An Effect can become a **Sustained Effect** whenever there is an active physical object (such as magnetic restraints, deployed gear, a smoke screen, or specialized equipment) or an ongoing continuous action sustaining it.

When an Effect is sustained, any set-aside Hits or mechanical benefits do not deplete when triggered. Instead, the full pool of set-aside Hits or advantages resets after each affected action or attempt. Sustained Effects can be applied to any Effect type where continuous operation makes logical narrative sense—most commonly Blocker Effects or ongoing Upgrade/Downgrade Effects. A Sustained Effect remains active until an opponent succeeds despite the penalty or until the physical object or continuous action sustaining it is removed, destroyed, or neutralized.

SUCCESS EFFECTS

Success Effects are activated during your **Success Roll**, allowing you to amplify the effectiveness or intensity of an action that has already proven successful:

- **Crit Effect:** The primary Success Effect across all Success Rolls. For every Hit (8+) sacrificed from your Success Roll pool, you add **+2 Success Points** directly to your highest remaining die value.
- **Push Effect:** Leverage raw momentum or physical force to reposition a target. For each Hit sacrificed from your Success Roll, you knock or force the target backward by up to 4 meters. If you wish to maintain pressure or stay in close proximity, you may move along with the target as they are displaced without spending additional movement. Push Effects can only be activated if **Strength** (or a similar physical power attribute) is included in the test's Attribute Pair; they cannot be activated with tests relying solely on finesse, mental, or social attributes.

REMOVING EFFECTS

Ongoing environmental hazards, physical restraints, and persistent blockers do not have to remain forever. If a character is in a position to eliminate or neutralize an active ongoing effect, they may spend **1 Action Point** on their turn to make a **Simple Test** determined by the GM. Each Hit scored on this Simple Test removes 1 set-aside Hit from the targeted effect, gradually breaking down the obstacle until it is completely eliminated.

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION

COMBINED MECHANICS IN ACTION: SYNDICATE CACHE BREACH

Acting under a Flotilla interdiction warrant, Jax and his team are raiding a fortified syndicate contraband cache defended by illegal combat drones. Engaging in close-quarters combat at the breached bulkhead, Jax declares, "I step in and swing my axe in a sweeping melee strike across the lead combat drone to tear open its plating while driving it back into its squadmate to clear the entryway."

The GM assesses the melee action and calls for a **Strength (5) + Strength (5)** Complex Test. Jax rolls 5d10 for his Action Roll based on his higher Attribute (**Strength 5**), producing `[3, 5, 8, 8, 9]`.

With three Hits (8, 8, and 9), Jax spends one Hit (8) to activate an Action Effect—an **Upgrade Effect**—stepping up one die on his upcoming Success Roll from a d10 to a **d12**. He leaves his remaining Hits (8 and 9) to ensure his Action Roll succeeds.

Moving to his Success Roll for his lower Attribute (**Strength 5**), Jax rolls 4d10 and 1d12 (modified by his Upgrade Effect). His roll yields `[5, 6, 7, 8]` on the d10s and 8 on the d12.

Jax scores two Hits (both 8s) on his Success Roll. He decides to activate two Success Effects:

- He spends his first 8 to activate a **Push Effect** (valid since his test relies on Strength), shoving the lead combat drone back 4 meters directly into its squadmate.
- He spends his second 8 to activate a **Crit Effect**, granting **+2 Success Points** to his highest remaining die.

The highest remaining die on his Success Roll is 7. By sacrificing his second 8 for Crit instead of keeping it as his base die, Jax increases his total from 8 to **9 Success Points** (7 + 2 = 9), neutralizing the lead drone while driving it clear of the doorway.